

Cardiff Community Meals

UX/UI Project Plan — from scratch to launch

Prepared for Sarah • 4 August 2026

This plan sequences the full design and delivery process for Cardiff Community Meals, from initial research through to public launch and beyond. Durations assume one small, focused team (roughly 1 designer, 1–2 developers, 1 project lead/trustee) working part-time alongside a community pilot — adjust up or down for team size. Phase 0 (the working prototype and planning documents) is already complete.

Phase 0 — Prototype (complete)

A working front-end prototype (HTML/CSS/JS on Bootstrap 5) and supporting planning documents already exist, covering the core flows: request/referral, donate & book, business showcase, impact tracking, and partner sign-up. This phase exists to pressure-test the concept with stakeholders before investing in full design and development.

- Cardiff Community Meals — Platform Plan (site map, data model, tech stack, safeguarding)
- User Stories & Solutions
- Clickable prototype covering all core flows

Phase 1 — Discovery & Research

Activities	Deliverables	Est. duration
Stakeholder interviews with potential referral partners (Age Connects Cardiff & Vale, Cardiff Council Meals on Wheels team, GP surgeries, hospital discharge coordinators). User interviews or short surveys with likely recipients, family referrers, and 3–5 local food businesses. Competitive/comparative review of existing services (Cardiff Council Meals on Wheels, Food Aid Referral, MyAid, ShareTheMeal). Accessibility needs-gathering specific to elderly and disabled users.	Research findings summary; refined personas; accessibility requirements brief	1.5–2 weeks
Define the problem statement and value proposition for each user type. Set success metrics (e.g. meals delivered/month, average time from request to first booking, business partner retention, donor repeat-donation rate).	Problem statement; success metrics doc	2–3 days

Phase 2 — Define & Strategise

Activities	Deliverables	Est. duration
Finalise information architecture and full sitemap. Map end-to-end user journeys for each persona (requester, donor, business, admin), including edge cases such as a request that never gets funded, or a business that has to decline a booking.	Sitemap; journey maps	1 week
Content strategy: tone of voice, plain-language guidelines (important given the audience includes elderly and unwell users), and a decision on bilingual English/Cymraeg support for core pages.	Content style guide; bilingual scope decision	3–4 days

Phase 3 — Design

Activities	Deliverables	Est. duration
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Low-fidelity wireframes for the core flows: request/refer, donate & book, track help, business showcase, partner sign-up.	Wireframe set (desktop + mobile)	1 week
Design system: colour palette, type scale, spacing, and a reusable component library (buttons, form fields, status badges, progress bars, cards) — building on the navy/coral palette and Bootstrap foundation already established in the prototype.	Design system / component library (e.g. in Figma)	1–1.5 weeks
High-fidelity mockups for every key screen, desktop and mobile, including empty states, error states, and confirmation screens.	High-fidelity mockups	2 weeks
Accessibility design pass: WCAG 2.1 AA colour contrast, minimum font sizes, focus states, screen-reader labelling, and keyboard-only navigation — essential given elderly/disabled end users.	Accessibility checklist applied to designs	3–4 days (parallel)
Clickable prototype of the highest-risk flows (request submission with consent, donation and booking) for usability testing.	Interactive prototype	3–4 days

Phase 4 — Validate

Activities	Deliverables	Est. duration
Usability testing with real target users — ideally recruited via a partner organisation such as Age Connects Cardiff & Vale — covering both older/disabled participants and family referrers. Separate short test with 2–3 prospective business partners on the sign-up and badge system.	Usability test findings; prioritised fix list	1–1.5 weeks
Safeguarding and legal review of the verification and consent flow with a trustee or data protection lead, checking against UK GDPR and the Data Protection Act 2018.	Signed-off safeguarding flow	3–5 days (parallel)
Iterate designs based on testing and review feedback.	Revised, validated designs	3–5 days

Phase 5 — Build

Activities	Deliverables	Est. duration
Build the production front end from the validated designs and component library.	Production front end	2–3 weeks
Build backend/API and database (PostgreSQL), authentication (including phone verification for requesters), and the admin console for request review and platform oversight.	Backend, database, admin console	3–4 weeks
Integrate payments (Stripe Connect, so funds can route to business partners) and notifications (email + SMS for status updates).	Payments live in test mode; notifications working	1–1.5 weeks
Build the business partner portal (accept/decline bookings, update status, view history).	Business portal	1.5–2 weeks
QA: cross-browser and mobile testing, automated accessibility scanning (e.g. axe), and manual screen-reader testing of the request and donation flows.	QA sign-off report	1 week (parallel with build)

Phase 6 — Pilot

Activities	Deliverables	Est. duration
Recruit a small pilot cohort: 2–3 Cardiff businesses and one referral partner organisation. Run a private beta limited to a small number of Cardiff postcodes, with manual admin verification of every request.	Live pilot with real requests, donations, and deliveries	3–4 weeks
Finalise legal/content pages (Terms of Service, Privacy Policy, Safeguarding Policy) and, if in scope, Welsh-language versions of core pages.	Published legal pages; bilingual pages if scoped	1 week (parallel)
Fix issues surfaced by real usage; refine copy, flows, and edge cases based on pilot feedback.	Stabilised, pilot-tested product	1–2 weeks

Phase 7 — Launch

Activities	Deliverables	Est. duration
Prepare launch assets: social media content, a short explainer for local press, and a joint announcement with the pilot referral partner.	Launch communications pack	1 week (parallel)
Public launch across Cardiff. Open business partner sign-up beyond the pilot cohort. Stand up a basic support channel (email/phone) for issues.	Live public platform	Launch day

Phase 8 — Post-launch & iterate

- Monitor the Impact dashboard and success metrics weekly for the first month, then monthly.
- Collect ongoing feedback from recipients, donors, and businesses (short surveys, review prompts).
- Run a lightweight safeguarding audit on a regular cadence (e.g. quarterly).
- Feed learnings into the wider roadmap — expanding to more Cardiff neighbourhoods, adding NHS/Council discharge integrations, and building out the bilingual Welsh experience, as set out in the original platform plan.

Indicative total timeline

Discovery through to public launch: roughly 14–18 weeks for a small team working part-time, assuming the pilot (Phase 6) runs for a full 3–4 week cycle before wider launch. This can compress significantly if the pilot is run informally alongside build, or extend if bilingual Welsh content and NHS/Council integrations are pulled into the initial launch scope rather than treated as later roadmap items.